

FASHION ICON

QUEEN NEFERTITI



△ PAINTED LIMESTONE BUST

One of the world's most famous images (c.1350 BCE, Egyptian Museum, Berlin), Nefertiti wears a flat-topped crown with a decorative ribbon and the remains of a *uraeus* – a protective cobra and royal symbol – on the front. Reddened lips and kohl-rimmed eyes typify the Egyptian love of make-up, while a decorative collar circles her neck and shoulders.

SENSUAL DRAPERY ▷

This red sandstone sculpture from the 14th century BCE is thought to be of Nefertiti. The contemporary garment style – finely pleated linen gathered at a point under the bust and extended over one shoulder – showcases a voluptuously hippered body symbolic of fertility.

The Egyptian Queen Nefertiti – whose name translates as “a beautiful woman has come” – is famed for possessing both political influence and great beauty. She was the wife of Akhenaten (named after his worship of the sun-disc, Aten), who reigned over 18th-dynasty Ancient Egypt in the 14th century BCE, during the New Kingdom era, and created a glittering city at Amarna. Nefertiti's allure is heightened by mystery – she seems to have disappeared without trace and theories abound about her fate.

Dressing a goddess

Contemporary statues and reliefs depict a woman with a striking face, and some show a curvaceous form highlighted by clinging garments. Such images would have been idealized according to the era's spiritual values. Nefertiti (along with her six daughters) would have constituted a living fertility goddess, emphasized by those images that portray her as wide hippered or in tight clothes; surviving evidence suggests that contemporary garments were in fact looser than depicted.

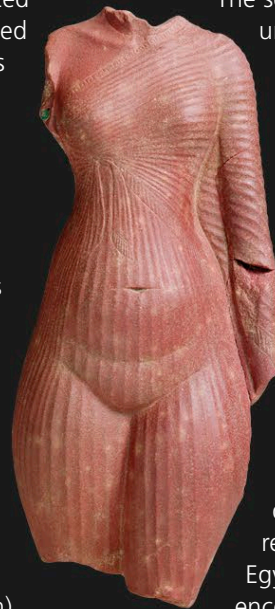
Nefertiti's clothing trademarks include a distinctive tall, straight-sided and flat-topped crown worn exclusively by her (left). Her garments were in the fine, pleated linen worn by New Kingdom royals and often depicted as being so fine that it became transparent – an aid to showing off the divine body. The linen was probably thicker in reality. Images of Nefertiti show how Egyptian linen lent itself to draping, folding, and well-defined pleating. Ancient Egyptian styles remained similar for centuries, but during the 18th dynasty in which Nefertiti lived, a more complex draping of larger pieces of fabric developed (alongside the basic *kalasiris* sheath).

Nefertiti is depicted wearing long, fine tunics draped in ways typical of New Kingdom times. Frequently the material's gathering appears to centre on one point, often close to the bust, creating a distinctive high-waisted shape; she appears with and without sleeves. A famous painted limestone statue of the royal couple, hand in hand, from around 1340 BCE, shows Nefertiti in a long, pleated linen tunic (often called a *haik*), caught between the waist and bust, gathered to produce undefined sleeves, and clinging especially closely to the lower body. As dyeing linen is difficult and it was the staple fibre, Egyptian clothing tends to be white. Rich colour was added with accessories by most levels of society.

An icon for the modern age

More than 3,500 years have elapsed yet Nefertiti and all things Egyptian continue to inspire today's designers.

The seminal blue-crowned bust (far left) was unearthed in 1912 and made its way to Berlin's Egyptian Museum, where it remains. On its Berlin unveiling, in 1923, this arresting image had an immediate impact on the public, cementing a fascination for all things Egyptian that had been fired the year before by the discovery of the tomb of boy-pharaoh Tutankhamun. “Egyptomania” gripped fashion design of the Art Deco era, from scarab jewellery to flowing, draped dresses, exotic embroidery, pyramid and lotus-flower motifs, dramatic deep headbands, and a love of Nile-green and bright blues. There was even a mummy wrap dress in the 1920s, an idea interpreted afresh in the skintight bandage dresses of the 2000s. Flappers' love of dark hair, red lips, and darkly outlined eyes was part of Egyptomania, and would most likely have been encouraged by Nefertiti's famed bust.



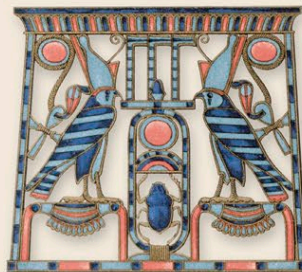
TIMELINE

1550 BCE Start of 18th dynasty, which brings in more complex, pleated garments

c.1353 BCE King Akhenaten's reign begins, with Nefertiti as his wife

c.1350 BCE Nefertiti appears on Theban reliefs

1340s BCE ▷ Akhenaten's court moves to Amarna. Nefertiti's image shows her in colourful jewellery similar to this brooch with sacred motifs such as falcons and scarabs



c.1340 BCE Nefertiti seems to vanish

c.1335 BCE Akhenaten's reign ends

1295 BCE End of 18th dynasty

1912 CE Nefertiti bust unearthed by Ludwig Borchardt

1923 ▷ Unveiling of Nefertiti bust in Berlin bolsters Art Deco-era Egyptomania. Egyptian motifs appear on 1920s dresses, jewellery, and ornaments

1920 CE

